been brought down to minimum levels in the state. The state's ADG (Additional Director General), law and order, Prashant Kumar, says, "We have strictly ensured that loudspeakers are taken down and no one is harassed on the basis of faith."

The Ramnavami and Hanuman Jayanti Shobha Yatra events, a source of friction and altercations every year since they coincide with the Ramzan month for Muslims, also went through without any violence, say UP authorities. Yogi had ordered that no religious procession would be taken out without official permission and the organisers giving an affidavit that they would maintain peace and harmony. "As many as 800 Ramnavami rallies were held in UP, a state of 250 million people. At the same time, *roza* and *iftar* were also being held as this is the month of Ramzan. Not a single incident of violence was reported," claims an official at the CM's office.

NO 'SELECTIVE ACTION'

In his second tenure, Yogi is trying hard to shed the "selective approach" charge of the Opposition, which says his decisions are biased and target the minority community. Last month's incident in Ayodhya was an eye-opener even for the Muslims. On April 28, locals found some 'objectionable material' placed outside a mosque. Investigations revealed that the accused were Hindutva activists who wanted to create trouble before Eid to "avenge the Jahangirpuri violence in Delhi". The main accused, Mahesh Mishra, is a known associate of the VHP (Vishva Hindu Parishad) and the Bajrang Dal. The police not only busted the plot but also had them booked under the National Security Act (NSA). The chief minister, apparently, was very clear that "no nuisance" will be allowed.

A similar incident was reported from Meerut's Hashimpura, where some BJP leaders wanted to organise a Devi Jagran on May 2. The local administration objected to it because of Ramzan and May 2 being the day Eid is celebrated. A video of a heated exchange between a local politician and the SHO went viral, with the former daring the police to stop the *jagran*. But senior officials intervened to get the event cancelled. The new inclusive initiatives have not gone unnoticed. Former UP DGP Prakash Singh tweeted: "Removal of more than 50,000 loudspeakers from religious shrines in UP—and that too without any visible opposition or clashes—has been one of the finest examples of good governance in any state in recent times."

The state's religious leaders have also given a thumbs-up. "We welcomed the CM's order, for we believe it is a general order for all communities. We have directed all the Sunni mosques to limit the sound and ensure that it does not carry outside the premises," says Maulana Khalid Rasheed Farangi Mahali, Naib Imam of the Aishbagh Eidgah in Lucknow. Hindu religious leaders, too, have been mostly enthusiastic. Raju Das, priest of the Hanumang Garhi temple of Ayodhya, says, "It's a good decision. People of all faiths must make sure that loudspeakers do not become a nuisance."

Political observers in UP see the current developments as preparations for a future role for Yogi in national politics. Prof. S.K. Dwivedi, former head of the political science department at Lucknow University, says, "It was the need of the hour. Yogi is looking for a bigger role in national politics, so he is trying to change his image. It's also a positive gesture and in the party's interests. I personally feel Yogi 2.0 is running more efficiently than the first term. They have started the anti-Romeo squads again, but no one is questioning them now, unlike the protests earlier."

Shilp Shikha Singh, assistant professor at Lucknow's Giri Institute of Development Studies, sees welcome signs in Yogi's unwillingness to indulge in "reactionary politics". "The way he handled the loudspeaker issue, he is trying to balance out things. Earlier, during the anti-CAA protests, there were many allegations of selective action. It may be a new approach targeting the 2024 general election where UP's 80 seats will be crucial. Yogi also wants to increase his acceptance within and outside the party," he says.

It's still early days, though, and despite the government's reassurances, some things remain the same. The 'bulldozer politics', ostensibly to flush out criminals and clear encroachments, continues. Just last week, a 43-year-old man, Rohtash, died of injuries sustained in a bulldozer-backed anti-encroachment drive in Bulandshahr. The law and order apparatus, too, seems to be in upheaval. State DGP Mukul Goel, who has held a number of critical posts in the past couple of years, was suddenly shunted out and accused of "neglecting work" and "inefficiency". There has also been a series of incidents where the police themselves are perpetrators in crimes, including rape. It has given enough ammunition for Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav to comment: "In Yogi Adityanath's second term, the crime situation has become twice as bad. Worst of all, the men in khaki are now being accused of criminally exploiting victims."

Akhilesh was referring to the Lalitpur rape case in which a Dalit minor and gang-rape victim was sexually assaulted by the SHO at the police station. Yogi may have a mind to change the system but his government has a long way to go before Ram *rajya* comes to Uttar Pradesh. ■



ANI

EVEN-HANDED APPROACH?

- CM Yogi instructs officials to ensure there are no power cuts on Eid, Akshaya Tritiya and Parashuram Jayanti
- Action taken against ex-Bajrang Dal activists in Ayodhya who wanted to create trouble before Eid
- Authorities intervene to get a *jagran* event on Eid day cancelled in Meerut's Hashimpura despite resistance from local BJP leaders